

SOUTH KOREA

Key Country Details: South Korea

Detail	Information
Full Name	Republic of Korea
Short Form	South Korea
Capital	Seoul
Region (UN)	Asia – Eastern Asia
Government Type	Unitary presidential constitutional republic
Head of State	President Yoon Suk-yeol
Head of Government	Prime Minister Han Duck-soo
Currency	South Korean Won (KRW)
UN Member Since	1991
MUN Standing	Active contributor in peacekeeping, development, disarmament, and democracy.

Book Recommendations on South Korean Foreign Policy & UN Engagement

1. **"South Korea at the Crossroads"** – Scott A. Snyder
<https://www.amazon.com/South-Korea-Crossroads-Autonomy-Relations/dp/0231185480>
2. **"South Korea's Grand Strategy: Making Its Own Destiny"** – Kyle Ferrier
<https://www.amazon.com/South-Koreas-Grand-Strategy-Destiny/dp/0815739509>
3. **"The Two Koreas: A Contemporary History"** – Don Oberdorfer & Robert Carlin
<https://www.amazon.com/Two-Koreas-Contemporary-History/dp/0465031234>
4. **"Korea: A New History of South and North"** – Victor Cha & Ramon Pacheco Pardo
<https://yalebooks.yale.edu/book/9780300278705/korea/>
5. **"The Korean Paradox: Domestic Political Divide and Foreign Policy in South Korea"** – Giulia Milani
<https://www.routledge.com/The-Korean-Paradox/Milani/p/book/9781032092294>

Research Table: South Korea & UNHRC

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
OHCHR Country Page – Korea	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/republic-korea	Human rights record and UN interactions.
UPR – Republic of Korea Reports	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/kr-index	Peer-reviewed human rights evaluation.
Amnesty International Reports – Korea	https://www.amnesty.org/en/location/asia-and-the-pacific/east-asia/south-korea/	Civil rights, freedom of expression.
Human Rights Watch – Korea	https://www.hrw.org/asia/south-korea	LGBTQ+, protest rights, freedom of press.
Freedom House – Korea Score	https://freedomhouse.org/country/south-korea/freedom-world/2024	Quantitative measure of freedoms.
UNGA Human Rights Speeches – Korea	https://gadebate.un.org	Official human rights discourse.

Special Rapporteur Visits	https://www.ohchr.org/en/special-procedures-human-rights-council	Reports on field visits to Korea.
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Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
OHCHR – South Korea Country Profile	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/republic-korea (amnesty.org, ohchr.org)	Baseline on treaty ratifications, OHCHR engagement, UN dialogue.
HRW – UPR Submission (Mar 2017 PDF)	https://uprdoc.ohchr.org/uprweb/downloadfile.aspx?file=EnglishTranslation&filename=8309	NGO critique on defamation laws, National Security Law, LGBT, and HIV travel restrictions.
Amnesty – UPR Submission (Jan 2023)	https://www.amnesty.org/en/documents/asa25/5761/2022/en/	Covers women's reproductive health, HIV discrimination, and defamation laws.
Amnesty – UPR Submission (Nov 2017 PDF)	https://www.amnesty.org/en/wp-content/uploads/2021/05/ASA2565002017ENGLISH.pdf	Highlights prolonged enforcement of defamation and restrictions on speech.
Amnesty – UPR Submission (Apr 2012 PDF)	https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/lib-docs/HRBodies/UPR/Documents/Session14/KR/AI-UPR-KOR-S14-2012-AmnestyInternational-E.pdf	Includes concerns on women's rights, LGBT protections, assembly freedom.
HRW – South Korea Country Page	https://www.hrw.org/asia/south-korea	Ongoing human rights issues: media freedom, discrimination, migrant rights.
State Dept – 2023 HR Report	https://www.state.gov/reports/2023-country-reports-on-human-rights-practices/south-korea/	US overview of civil liberties, press restrictions, LGBT, labour.
Freedom House – South Korea Profile	https://freedomhouse.org/country/south-korea/freedom-world/2024	Rates civil/political and internet freedoms—contextual for UNHRC evaluation.

UPR Info – Republic of Korea Hub	https://upr-info.org/en/review/korea-republic	Aggregates all UPR cycle documents, including NGO inputs.
HRW – Defamation Law Threats to Press Freedom	https://www.hrw.org/news/2014/12/14/south-korea-stop-using-criminal-defamation-laws	Shows legal pressures on journalists—central to Council Item 2.
HRW – LGBT Sex Education and Reprimands	https://www.hrw.org/news/2017/02/17/south-korea-backslides-sex-education	Documents removal of LGBT inclusion from curricula.
UPR Submission – Assembly & Policing (2017)	https://policehumanrightsresources.org/submission-for-the-un-universal-periodic-review-korea-2017	Covers policing assemblies and excessive force issues.
OHCHR – UNDP Treaty Ratification Dashboard	https://tbinternet.ohchr.org/_layouts/15/TreatyBodyExternal/Countries.aspx?CountryCode=KOR&Lang=en	Shows which core treaties South Korea has acceded to and reported on.
Freedom House – Internet Freedom Score	https://freedomhouse.org/country/south-korea/freedom-net/2024	Reports on government surveillance, content filtering—a key digital rights issue.
HRW – Korea Human Rights Updates Page	https://www.hrw.org/asia/south-korea	Timely updates on rights developments—especially for UN discussions.
OHCHR – UPR Cycle 14 NGO Summary	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/upr-republic-of-korea-stakeholder-info-s14	Lists NGO contributions used in Council review.

10 Unique Aspects: South Korea & UNHRC

1. **Cold-War Era Speech Laws Still Enforced:** South Korea upholds the National Security Law and criminal defamation laws, which limit freedom of expression—something that has raised significant concerns for the UN Human Rights Council.
2. **Backtracking on LGBT and Sex Education Rights:** LGBT content was taken out of sex education due to pressure from conservative groups, which sparked discussions about digital and educational issues during Council debates.
3. **Defamation Used Against Journalists:** Civil defamation lawsuits have put a damper on investigative journalism—a fundamental problem that Human Rights Watch has pointed out.
4. **Assembly and Protest Policing Issues:** NGO UPR submissions highlight the issue of excessive police force during crowd control, linking it to concerns raised in UNHRC Item 2 and Item 4.

5. **HIV-Related Travel Restrictions Persist:** South Korea continues to impose travel restrictions based on HIV status, which infringes on individuals' rights to health and equality.
 6. **Host of DPRK Accountability Mechanisms:** The OHCHR's office in Seoul was set up to assist the DPRK Commission of Inquiry, highlighting the Human Rights Council's importance in the region.
 7. **Strong Civil Society Influence via UPR:** NGOs such as Human Rights Watch and Amnesty International play a crucial role in shaping UPR reviews, showcasing the dynamic involvement of civil society.
 8. **Robust Internet but Watchful Surveillance:** High internet freedom ratings often go hand in hand with government filtering, which raises some serious concerns about privacy and freedom of expression at the Council.
 9. **Mixed Treaty Compliance:** While South Korea has signed several key treaties, there are still some reporting gaps that we can keep an eye on through the OHCHR dashboard.
 10. **Regional Human Rights Advocate with Domestic Challenges:** Even though South Korea is at the forefront of regional initiatives, it still grapples with its own internal human rights challenges, making its situation at the UNHRC quite complex.
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